Lautari

[lɐuˈtari]

Board game description

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Lautari

Lautari is a board game that combines a simple design and easy-to-understand rules with strategic depth, offering players a wide range of combinations and tactical possibilities. In this two-player game, opponents compete for control of the central area on the game board. The ability to change the roles of pieces and create a variety of combinations adds extra complexity and challenge to the game.

Success in the game requires a balance of carefully planned and timely executed actions, as every decision can influence the course and outcome of the game. The complexity increases due to the central cell being connected to all inner ring cells, allowing for quick maneuvers and rapid position changes. The victory conditions encourage thoughtful strategy, rewarding players who rely on calculated combinations rather than reckless aggression.

Game board

The game board consists of two starting positions (home areas), each containing three rows with five cells per row, and a central area where most of the action takes place. The central area includes a single central cell surrounded by three rings - inner, middle, and outer - each containing 20 cells. The central area is connected to the home areas through two additional connection arcs, each with five cells in each.

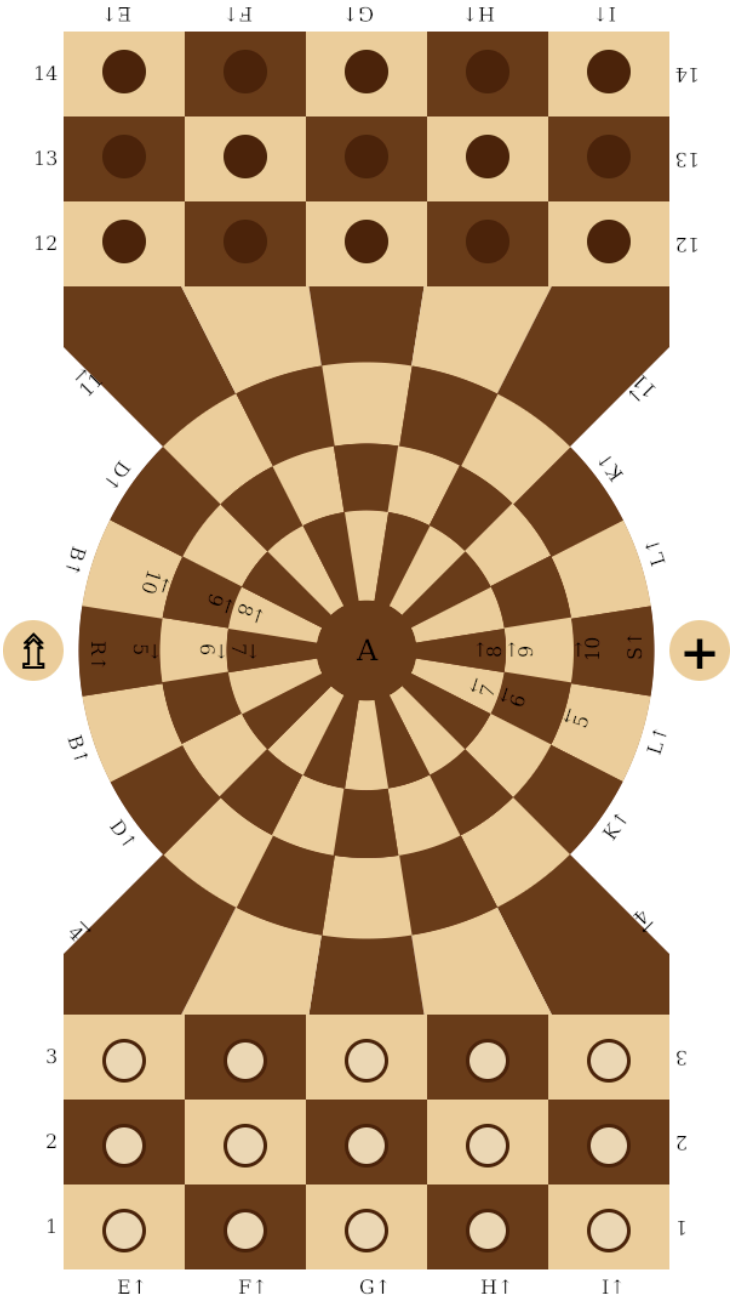


Figure 1: Lautari game board and starting position

Pawn

Each player starts with 15 Pawns, placed in their home areas in three rows of five pieces each. One player controls the whites, while the other controls the blacks. White moves first. A step is a movement of a piece to any adjacent cell that shares a common edge with its current cell. The central cell is connected to all cells in the inner ring. A piece cannot move onto a cell occupied by a friendly piece. A Pawn can move one step. Players cannot skip their turn. After making a move or performing another action, the turn passes to the opponent.

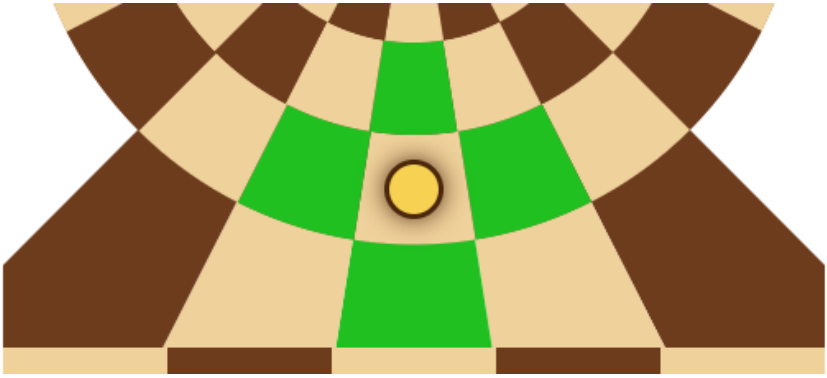


Figure 2: Pawn and its movement range

Capturing

If a piece ends its move on a cell occupied by an opponent's piece, the opponent's piece is captured and removed from the board. Any piece can capture any other piece. There are no forced moves in the game, meaning a player can choose not to capture a piece even if they can.

Infantry

A Pawn can be promoted to an Infantry if it is placed between two friendly pieces. The three-piece formation must be in a straight line or along a circular arc. Diagonal lines do not count, as the cells must be connected by shared edges. If the middle Pawn is on the central cell, the other two pieces must be on opposite cells of the inner ring. This formation can be created anywhere on the board, as long as the piece in the middle (the one being promoted) is outside the home areas (not on the 1st, 2nd, 3rd, 12th, 13th, or 14th rows) - it must be in the central area or on the connection arcs.

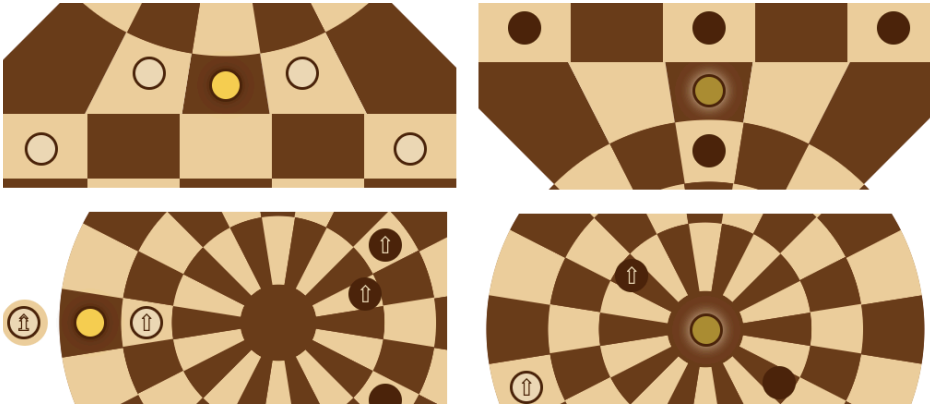


Figure 3: Various formations for promoting into an Infantry

From the moment all white Pawns that initially stood on the 3rd home row have moved in any direction (including sideways), this row can be used to promote Infantry. This rule also applies to the 2nd and 1st home rows once the respective Pawns have moved. The black player applies the similar rule for the 12th, 13th, and 14th home rows.

After creating a three-piece formation, the promotion does not happen automatically; it can be done in the next turn. Promotion is not mandatory - the player can choose to make another move or action instead. Promotion requires one turn, replacing the Pawn piece with the Infantry piece. Once the promotion is done, the turn passes to the opponent.

The Infantry is denoted by the symbol ⇧, and it can move up to 2 steps in one turn. The steps can change direction; for example, the piece can move one step forward and one step left in a single turn. The Infantry cannot jump over other pieces. The Infantry cannot "skip" a turn by moving to one cell and then back in the same turn. If the Infantry makes a move, it must end on a different cell. There is no limit to how many Infantry pieces can be in the game. Players can even promote all 15 Pawns into Infantry.

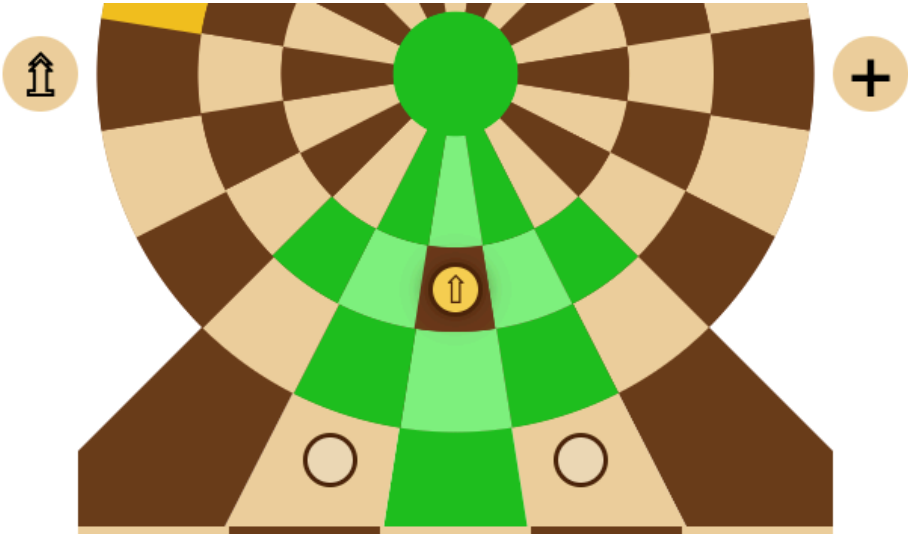


Figure 4: Infantry and its movement range

Rider

If a piece reaches the Rider promotion cell (a circular cell marked with ⇮, reachable via the r5 cell), it is promoted into a Rider. The Rider piece is denoted by the symbol ⇮. This piece can move up to 3 steps in one turn and can jump over other pieces. Like the Infantry, the Rider can take steps in different directions and cannot "skip" a move. There is no limit to how many Riders can be in the game. The Rider is a very effective piece due to its range - a Rider on the central cell covers all 3 rings, while a Rider in the inner ring covers both the inner and middle rings.

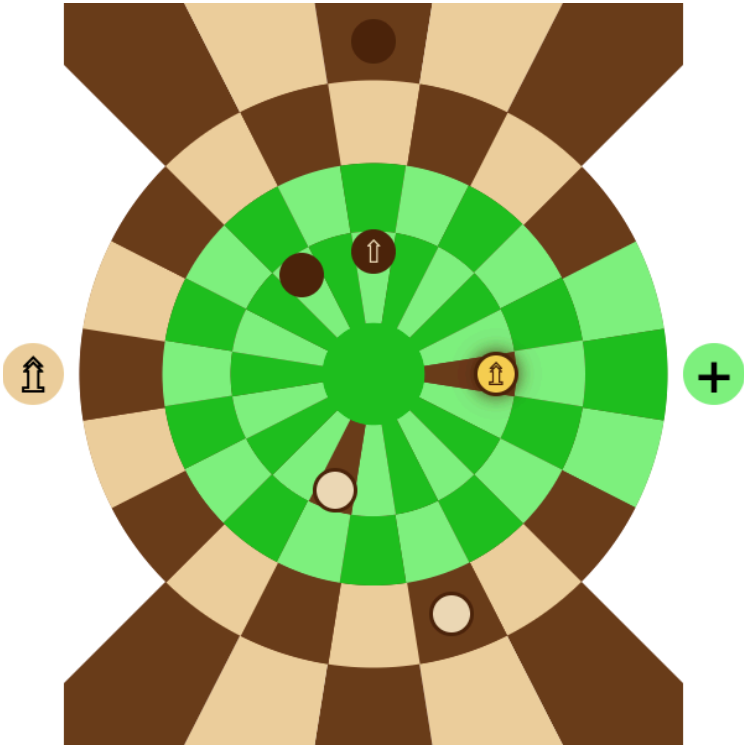


Figure 5: Rider in the inner ring and its movement range

Sentinel

If a piece reaches the Sentinel promotion cell (a circular cell marked with +, reachable via the s10 cell), it is promoted into a Sentinel. The Sentinel piece is denoted by the symbol +, and it can move up to three steps in one turn, but cannot jump over other pieces.

The Sentinel piece can use its move to revive a piece that was captured in the previous turn, as long as the captured piece was no more than two steps away from the Sentinel, and there are no other pieces in the way. This action undoes the previous turn, returning the captured piece to the board as a Pawn and moving the opponent's piece back to its previous position. The piece is revived as a Pawn, losing its previous role, and gains immunity from being captured for one turn.

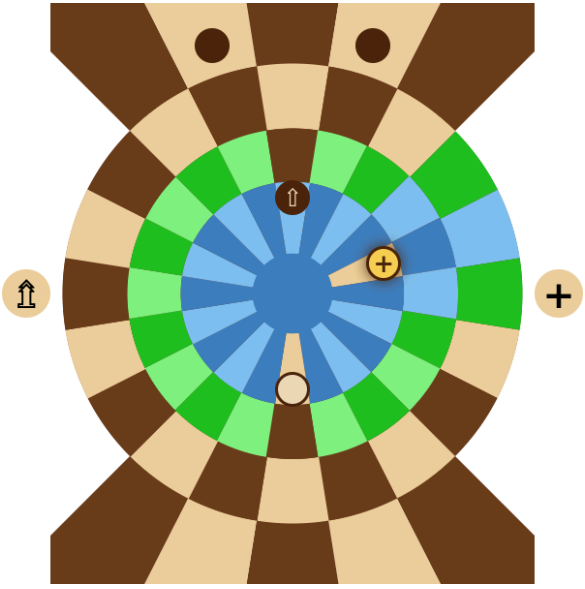


Figure 6: Sentinel and its movement and revival range

Sentinel's special rules

Each player can only have one Sentinel at a time. If a piece reaches the Sentinel promotion cell when the player already has a Sentinel, the piece's role does not change. If the Sentinel is captured or promoted into a Rider, the player can promote another piece into a Sentinel. If a piece is already standing on the Sentinel cell when the Sentinel is captured or promoted into a Rider, in order to promote it into a Sentinel, the piece must step off the cell and then step back onto it.

If the opponent captures a piece on the Rider or Sentinel promotion cell, and the Sentinel revives it, the piece returns as a Pawn, and it must step off the promotion cell and step back onto it to be promoted again. If the capture results in the opponent's piece being promoted (for example, an Infantry captures a piece on the Rider promotion cell, itself becoming a Rider), the revival reverts this promotion.

A Sentinel on the central (A) cell can only be captured by another Sentinel or a Rider. The Sentinel in the central cell loses this immunity for one turn if it has just revived a piece.

Unlike the Infantry promotion, which requires one turn, pieces are promoted into Riders or Sentinels upon reaching the respective cell. They can perform their actions in the next turn. A Rider can be promoted into a Sentinel (if the player doesn’t already have one) and vice versa, losing its previous abilities. Riders and Sentinels can’t be promoted into Infantry.

Main goal

The goal of the game is to gain control of the center. This is done by placing any of your promoted pieces (Infantry, Rider, or Sentinel) on the central (A) cell and any two of your pieces on the opposite cells of the inner ring. This victory awards 2 points to the winner, while the loser receives 0 points.

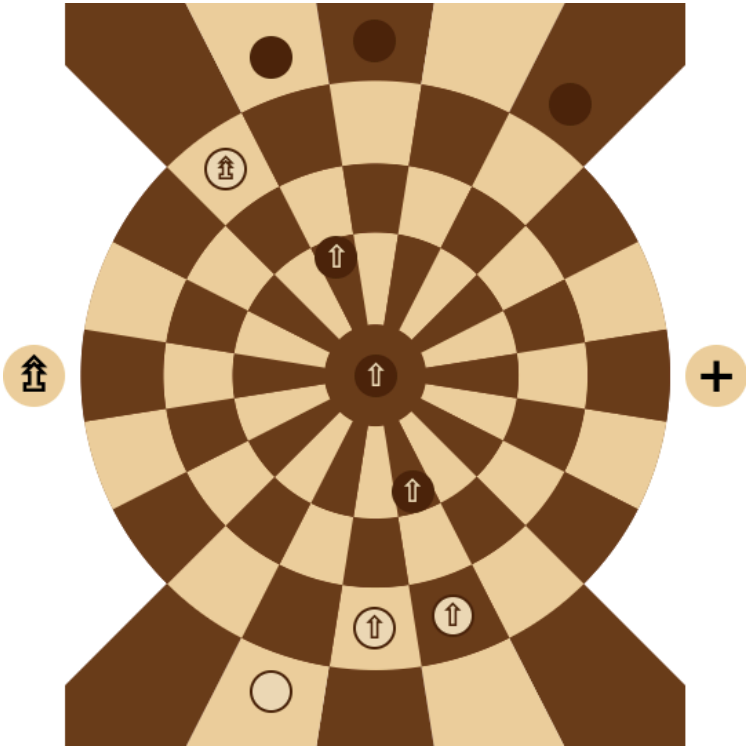


Figure 7: Winning position

If, in that position, an unpromoted Pawn occupies the A cell, the victory is not granted. However, since the winning position allows to promote the Pawn into an Infantry, this can be done in the next turn, granting victory at once.

Special winning position

A winning position, that consists of a Sentinel on the central cell and two Riders, grants the winner 3 points.

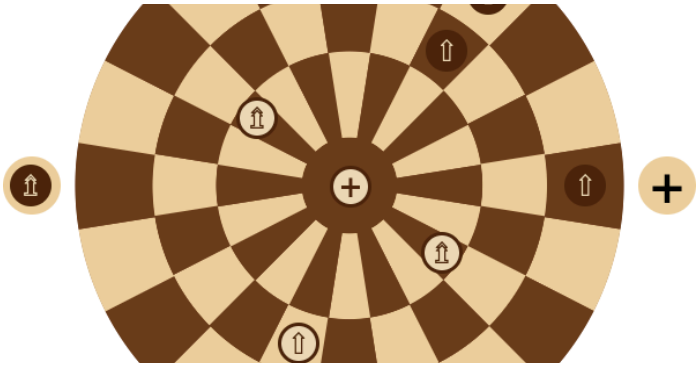


Figure 8: Three point victory

Domination victory

The game can also be won by domination. If one player captures all of the opponent's pieces while still having at least eight pieces on board, that player is awarded a domination victory. This victory type gives the winner 1 point, while the loser receives 0 points. If the last piece is taken while finishing the winning position, the winner gets 1 point.

Draw

A draw is automatically declared if a player has fewer than three pieces left on board, and the opponent has fewer than eight pieces. A draw can also be declared at any other time if both players mutually agree. In the case of a draw, both players receive ½ point.

Rating system

To evaluate players' experience and skill, a special rating system is used. Each new player initially has a rating of 1000. After each game, players' ratings change - a specified value is added to the winner and subtracted from the loser. To determine this value, the following formula is used:

$$p\left(\frac{1.998}{1+e^{0.002d}}+0.001\right)\left(\frac{1.6}{1+e^{0.01v}}+0.2\right)$$

where **p** is the outcome value (0 - a draw, 2 - a domination victory, 12 - a two-point win, and 18 - a three-point win), **d** is the rating difference (winner's minus loser's rating), and **v** is the difference in positional evaluation (winner's minus loser's value). The positional evaluation is calculated using this logic: the base value of the piece (pawn - 1, infantry - 3, rider - 6, sentinel - 10) is added to its position value - the farther from the center, the lower the value. In the farthest row from the center (row 1 or 14), the value is 0. With each next row, the value increases by one, up to the inner ring where the value is 6. The central cell has a value of 8. For example, an infantry in the inner ring has a total value of 3 + 6 = 9. The values of all pieces for a player are summed to give the player's positional value. The difference in these values is used in the formula.

Example: A two-point win by a player with a rating of 1100 against a 1200-rated player, with positional evaluations of 34 and 28, will result in the winner gaining 13.86 rating points (rounded to two decimal places), subtracting from the loser.

Move notation system

Each turn is recorded on a new line, with the players' moves or actions separated by a hyphen "`-`".

A player's move is recorded by indicating the starting and ending cell identifiers: `e3 e4`.

Promotions into an Infantry are noted with the cell identifier, followed by the promotion symbol "`^`" and the letter "`I`": `f4^I`.

Promotions into a Rider or Sentinel are recorded as a move, followed by the promotion symbol "`^`" and the Rider or Sentinel symbol – `R` or `S`, respectively: `b10 r4^R`.

A capture is recorded as a move with the "x" symbol: `i8 h7x`.

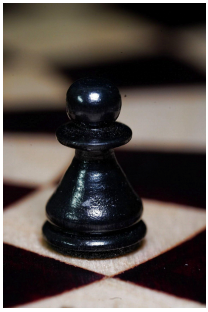
The Sentinel's revival action is recorded by noting the cell where the Sentinel is located, followed by "`+`" and the previous move's cell identifiers, separated by a comma:

`k10*g8,k8` (Sentinel on k10, moving the piece back from k8 to g8 and reviving a Pawn on k8)

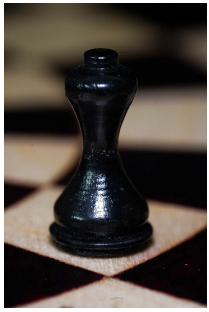
Notation examples

```
1:  e3 e4   -  e12 e11
2:  g3 g4   -  e11 e10
3:  f3 f4   -  e10 d10
4:  f4^I    -  d10 b10
5:  f4 e5   -  b10 r5
6:  e5 e7   -  r5 r4^R
7:  e7 a    -  r4 d5
8:  a s8    -  d5 e4x
```

Pieces in the physical version of the game

A Pawn

An Infantry




A Rider




A Sentinel

The board of the physical version of the game



The game invented by Aleksejs Ivanovs

The screenshots of the board in the document were taken from the game's digital demo version, which can be found at https://lautari.app

Rules version 1.02

2024